

The Netherlands

Ratio: 2:3 **Adopted:** February 19, 1937 **Usage:** National and Civil

Blue and white originally represented faith in God



In the mid-17th century, red, rather than orange, was made the official color

Europe



Independent from Spain in the 16th century, the **Netherlands** was a republic until the Napoleonic Wars and became a kingdom in 1814.

The first *Stadtholder*, or ruler, of the Dutch Republic was William of Orange, who joined with Dutch nationalists and led the struggle for independence from Spain.

THE PRINSVLAV

Partly out of respect for him, the first flag adopted by the Dutch, was a horizontal tricolor of orange, white, and blue (*see page 6*). It became known as the *Prinsenvlag* and was based on the livery of William of Orange. The orange dye was particularly unstable and tended to turn red after a while, so in the mid-17th century, red was made the official color. The flag has flown since then, but was only confirmed

by Royal Decree in 1937. As the first revolutionary flag, it has had a seminal influence throughout the world, particularly on the Pan-Slavic colors of Russia.

Until about 1800, in the case of both the orange- and red-striped versions, the number of stripes and their order frequently varied.

ARMS OF THE NETHERLANDS

The Dutch coat of arms depicts a golden lion on a blue shield, holding a sword and a sheaf of arrows. It is a combination of the coat of arms of the Dutch Republic and that of the House of Orange. The seven arrows represent the seven original provinces in the Netherlands.